

How to Stop Overthinking - Printable Cards and Trackers

From *How to Stop Overthinking* by Hannah Kessler (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

The Question-Swap Card

Cut this out and keep it where you will see it - a desk drawer, a wallet, the back of your phone.

Instead of	Ask
Why did I say that?	What exactly did I say, and what happened next?
Why does this always happen to me?	What happened this time, specifically?
Why am I like this?	What did I do in that moment, and what will I do in the next one?
What if it all goes wrong?	What is the first thing that would have to happen, and how would I know?
Why can't I cope?	Which specific part is hardest, and what would help with that part?
What does this say about my life?	What is the next concrete thing to do about it?
Why did they say that?	What did they actually say? What is the most ordinary explanation?
Why am I still not over this?	What is different now compared with a year ago?
What's wrong with me?	What do I need in the next hour?

Three rules

1. Be almost absurdly specific.
2. Stay with the situation, not with yourself.
3. Follow it to an action, then stop.

Am I Ruminating, or Solving This?

Three questions. Ten seconds.

1. Am I any closer to doing something than I was twenty minutes ago?	If no, and I have been round the loop twice, this is not problem-solving.
2. Is this about a specific situation, or about me as a person?	"About me" is nearly always rumination.
3. Could I write what I am trying to decide in one sentence?	If not, there is no decision being made.

If it is rumination or worry: swap the question, or postpone it to worry time.

If it is problem-solving: carry on, concretely, until you reach an action - then stop.

My Worry Time

My slot (same time daily, 15-30 min, not late, not in bed)	
My place (not the bedroom, not the sofa)	
Started on	

The rules

1. When a worry arrives during the day, note it in one line and say "not now - at [time]".
2. Return attention to what you were doing. Expect to repeat this many times at first.
3. At the slot, actually sit and worry about the list, for the full time.
4. When the slot ends, stop, and do something with your hands.

Today's postponed list

Time noted	The worry, in one line	Still mattered at worry time?

The point of the last column: most people find a good share of the morning's urgent worries have gone flat by evening. That is information about what they were worth.

The Two-Week Plan Tracker

Rate **time lost to looping** out of ten, once a day at the same time. Rate the looping, not your mood.

Day	What I added	Rating /10	Note
1	Notice only		
2	Notice only		
3	Question swap		
4	Question swap		
5	Question swap		
6	+ Worry time		
7	+ Worry time		
8	+ Labelling		
9	+ Labelling		
10	+ Physical interruption		
11	+ Physical interruption		
12	My worst situation		
13	My worst situation		

14	Review		
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Keep this. During a bad week later on, memory will tell you nothing ever improved. This page will disagree, and it will be right.

The Decision Sheet

For the choice that has been circling for weeks.

The decision, in one sentence	
Is it reversible?	yes / no
If reversible: decide by (soon)	
If irreversible: decide by	
My research budget until then (3 specific things)	
My minimum standard - what makes an option good enough (write this BEFORE looking at more options)	

The four better questions

	My answer
What would I advise a friend in exactly this position?	
Which option will I regret <i>not</i> trying?	

What is the worst realistic outcome of each, and could I live with it?	
If I had to decide in ten minutes, which would I pick?	

After deciding: re-opening the comparison is rumination, not diligence.

Testing the Beliefs About Thinking

From Chapter 4. These are tests, not arguments. Do them rather than think about them.

Belief	The test	What actually happened
"I have no control over my thoughts"	Postpone one worry for two hours	
"Worrying prepares me"	Write down the specific action this week's worrying produced	
"If I keep going I'll find the answer"	Note tonight's conclusion; compare with last week's on the same subject	
"This thinking will make me ill"	Note the prediction and the date; check back in a month	

When to Get Help

Tick anything that applies and take this to your doctor.

	Applies
It is affecting work, sleep or relationships, persistently	
I did the two-week plan properly and nothing changed	
Low mood or anxiety is the bigger problem	
I am checking, seeking reassurance, or doing rituals to feel safe	
I am using alcohol or something else to stop the thinking	
The thoughts are intrusive, repugnant, and unlike me - about harm, contamination, or something against my values	
Any thought of harming myself	

The distinction that matters most

Rumination is about real events and your own character. It feels like your own thinking.

Obsessions in OCD are unwanted, intrusive and experienced as alien and repugnant - and the reviewing, analysing and self-reassuring that follows is a *compulsion*, not rumination. Several techniques in this book can feed it. OCD has its own effective treatment, **exposure and response prevention**. Ask for it by name.

What to say at the appointment

"I ruminate, it is affecting my life, and I have tried a structured self-help approach."
Ask about CBT - and specifically about rumination-focused CBT or metacognitive therapy.
If sleep is the main problem, ask about CBT for insomnia.

Any thought of harming yourself is a today conversation. In the United States, the 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline can be called or texted at any hour.